

The Dialogue of the Savior

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Editor's Introduction

Introduced by Helmut Koester and Elaine H. Pagels

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The title *The Dialogue of the Savior* appears in the incipit and the explicit of the manuscript and is apparently a later addition. No specific author is indicated anywhere in the text. But the speaker is the “Savior” or the “Lord” (he is never called Jesus or Jesus Christ) in conversation with his disciples Judas, Mary, and Matthew. In this respect, the title “dialogue” is appropriate, except for the first section of the text (120,3-124,22) which is an uninterrupted monologue of the Savior. The text is preserved only in this somewhat fragmentary manuscript, and it is not referred to or quoted in any ancient source. Thus, no external attestation for the date of its composition is available.

The *Dialogue of the Savior* is a writing of considerable complexity, and its several parts exhibit a great variety in style and content. It is best seen as a compilation of various generations of Christianity and composed in its extant form, originally in Greek, some time during the 2nd century. Parallels to the author's understanding of baptism in deutero-Pauline epistles suggest a date close to the turn of the first century.

The primary source was a dialogue between the Lord and three disciples. This source is preserved in the following sections of the extant work: 124,23-127,19; 128,23-129,16; 131,19-133,21(7); 137,3-146,20, i.e., in about 65% of the present text. These sections are characterized by brief questions, usually from one of the named disciples (sometimes by all disciples) and equally brief answers of the Lord. Sometimes these questions and answers are expanded into longer units discussing a particular topic. Traditional sayings of Jesus used in these questions and answers have parallels in the Gospels of Matthew, Luke, and John, and particularly in *The Gospel of Thomas*. However, a literary dependence upon any of these writings seems unlikely. Rather, the sayings tradition used here appears to be an independent parallel to the one used in *The Gospel of Thomas* and the Gospel of John.

The form of these brief dialogue units parallels the dialogues found in the Gospel of John. In contrast to some gnostic dialogues which are actually secondarily arranged theological discourses (such as *The Sophia of Jesus Christ* and *Pistis Sophia*), the dialogues of the Gospel of John and of *The Dialogue of the Savior* are not free compositions of an author, but elaborations and interpretations of traditional sayings. In some instances, the dialogical development of the sayings tradition in our document is less advanced and theologically less complex than the Johannine parallels. This would argue for a date of the original dialogue source of this document before the end of the first century.

The sequence of the topics explored in these dialogues has close parallels in sayings of *The Gospel of Thomas*, especially in its saying 2 about the seeking, finding, marvelling, ruling and resting. That saying presents an eschatological timetable which is further explored in the dialogues of this writing. The disciples have sought and found and marvelled, but their ruling and resting will come only in the future. At the present time, they still carry the burden of the flesh, i.e., the body and earthly labor or, in the words of this writing, of “the works of womanhood.” Mary who recognizes this receives the highest praise. This theme, the continuation of the works of the female, i.e., the continuation of the human race through childbirth, is prominent in the last portion of the dialogue. It deals with the role of the female in the process of salvation more explicitly than most other early Christian writings (close parallels can be found in *The Gospel of the Egyptians*, quoted by Clement of Alexandria), and it gives Mary a very high estimate as “a woman who had understood completely” (139,11-13).

In the final form of the document, several other traditional pieces have been added to the original dialogue: 1) Fragments of a creation myth (127,19-131,18) which is based upon Gen 1-2. The myth relates how water, originally separated from the earth by a wall of fire, made the world fruitful. In 128,1-129,12, the author has interrupted the account of this myth in order to interpret the term spirit. 2) A cosmological wisdom list (133,23-134,24). The author has added comments about the root of wickedness and about baptism. 3) An apocalyptic vision of which fragments are still recognizable in 134,24-137,3. The vision, taking place on a high mountain from where the whole of heaven and earth can be seen, originally spoke about the rescue of a soul and its installation before God in a new garment. The process is explained by an angelic figure called “Son of Man,” a title which *The Dialogue of the Savior* never uses for Jesus.

The final author opened his compilation of these materials with an intriguing section (120,2-124,22), consisting of an exhortation, a prayer of thanksgiving and a gnostic discourse about the passage of the soul through the heavenly powers. This section employs established Christian soteriological language with allusions to passages from the New Testament epistles; it also contains a reference to the Gospel of John (Jn 1:18). With this introduction the entire dialogue is placed into a new context: baptismal initiation. The baptismal theology resolves the conflict between the “already” of a realized eschatology and the “not yet” of a futuristic eschatology. As baptism is understood in the same way as in Eph 2:1-6 and Col 3:1-4, those who are baptized have already passed through death into true life. Metaphorical and mythical language is thus related to a cultic act for the expression of realized eschatology.

Yet, receiving visions in the context of baptism is not the culmination of the experience of redemption. Instead, through the utilization and interpretation of the older dialogue used in the composition, the author presents a discussion of the complex eschatological situation of the disciples. Although the disciples have already sought and found and have marvelled at visions, have experienced the indwelling of the living God and passed through the powers in the experience of baptism, their final entry into ruling and resting is still to come. Their present existence is defined as work in behalf of the revelation, so that they, like their Lord, may save others and “reveal the greatness of the revealer,” while they are still wearing the flesh, carrying a burden just as the Lord himself. This also indicates that the “Lord” who is speaking in this dialogue is not the exalted Lord but the “earthly” Jesus. The “place of truth” is not defined in terms of otherworldly existence, but as the place where the Lord is. This emphasis upon the tasks of a

Christian life in this world implies that the “dissolution of the works of womanhood” does not suggest a metaphysically motivated sexual asceticism, but speaks of the secret birth through the one who “is coming from the Father.” In spite of the evident employment of gnostic language in the description of the baptismal experience, *The Dialogue of the Savior* cannot be understood as the simple product of gnostic theology. Rather, it resembles the Gospel of John in its attempt to reinterpret the sayings of Jesus in the horizon of gnostic thought.